

Every business executive is going to make mistakes in his career. The important thing is to learn from them—and avoid repetition. But there are certain recurring situations and procedures which seem to invite error and misjudgment. It is up to the alert executive to anticipate and evaluate these "traps." As for those blunders and errors of judgment which will inevitably occur, the same

"millionaire" mentality which ensures success will survive *and* profit by them.

Like most people, I'd much prefer to have the memories of my mistakes fade quietly into oblivion, but there are many I cannot forget. Among them are three monumental blunders I shall always remember.

The first dates back to my days in the Oklahoma oil fields. Buying the oil lease on a property located in an area later known as the "Yale Pool," I hired a geologist to inspect the site and to recommend whether or not I should drill.

"There's no oil on the land," he reported. "The property is worthless. The best thing you can do is get rid of the lease!"

I followed his advice and sold. A short time later, the Yale Pool proved to be a rich oil-producing area. I'd thrown away a fortune.

My second giant—but hardly economy-sized—blunder was made in 1931. Firms in which I already held substantial interests and I bought more than two million dollars' worth of Mexican Seaboard Oil Company common

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at prevailing Depression-era lows. Then, the stock market took another downturn. I was certain we'd made a safe and sound investment in Mexican Seaboard, but my fellow directors feared that the market would go even lower.

"We can't take any more risks," they argued. "We have to unload." Outvoted, I finally went along with the majority. The firms—and I—sold